

THE LEGEND OF KARAT

Hailing from a community hostile to the Reds, his academic grounding made him take a Left turn

Keralites, who gave the world its first democratically elected communist government, can be proud that one of their own now heads the party that is virtually a parallel power centre in Delhi. Yet, that sense of elation is tinged with irony. Born in Rangoon, Burma, where his father worked with the British Railways, the Malayalee is quite uncomfortable in his mother tongue. The thousands that throng the maidans when the CPI(M) general secretary makes an appearance get to see him, but the words they hear are that of an interpreter.

Palakkad, Kerala's rice bowl, has long been a red bastion, thanks to its large community of famished agricultural workers. But the upper caste landlords of

until last year that she saw him for the first time. "When he was in Palakkad, I phoned him and ordered him to come. He was surprised but came immediately." The family, however, has a grouse. No one has seen his wife. "I told him to bring Brinda here and he said, she has her own work to do," says Sathyabhama, a cousin.

As India's youngest ever communist general secretary and the first from the post-Independence generation, Karat does not suffer from the many hang-ups of the past. Born on February 7, 1948, Karat lost his father while still in school and moved to Madras with his mother Radha and sister Kamala. Tragedy struck again as Kamala died barely into her teens. His mother took up

a job as an LIC agent to give him a good education.

It was as an undergraduate student of Economics at the famed Madras Christian College that his flirtation with the communist movement began. The introvert slowly began to come out of his shell. At least one classmate recalls his bond with his Jawa motorcycle and his fondness for Hollywood movies. Karat is said not to have missed a single Michael Caine thriller. While in college, he won a trip to Japan in an essay competition conducted by *The Hindu*. That was also the beginning of Karat's enduring bond with the

paper's editor N. Ram and also with P. Chidambaram, who is now finance minister.

After graduating with a gold medal, "the most outstanding student" won a scholarship to Britain's Edinburgh University for a Masters' degree in politics. It was here, under professors like Victor Kiernan, the famed Marxist historian, that his politics became more strident. His active participation in anti-apartheid agitations led to his rustication from the university for a year, which, however, was withdrawn on "good behaviour". By the time he returned to India, Karat was a dyed-in-the-wool communist. He wasted no time formally enrolling in CPI(M) and became an aide to A.K. Gopalan, the legendary communist leader from Kerala. The rest, of course, is history.

by M.G. Radhakrishnan



ROOTS OF THE RADICAL: Karat with his parents in Burma; in his youth

Elappully, a village perched on the border with Tamil Nadu, have traditionally remained hostile to the Reds. Even today, despite a Nair from Elappully heading CPI(M), it is almost impossible to find another comrade even among Karat's numerous relatives in the village. "None of us are communists, but we are proud of Prakash," says Karat Sundareswara Menon, 77, his cousin and a resident of the village, adding that he knows precious little about the famous Marxist. "He was born and grew up outside Kerala and has visited the village only three or four times. But we always knew him to be a well-mannered, disciplined and studious boy," he says.

At 86, Omana Amma, the only surviving sister of Karat's mother, is his closest relative. She lives next to his ancestral house, which is now unoccupied. But it wasn't